Georgiy **Syunyaev**

Assistant Professor of Political Science · Vanderbilt University

Room 351, Commons Center, 230 Appleton Place, Nashville, TN 37203

+1 (917) 873-68-72 | g.syunyaev@vanderbilt.edu | gsyunyaev.com | gerasy1987 | 0000-0002-4391-6313 | google scholar

Appointments

Department of Political Science, Vanderbilt University — *Nashville, TN, US*

Assistant Professor of Political Science — *Aug 2023 – Present*

Institutions and Political Inequality Unit, Berlin Social Science Center (WZB) — *Berlin, Germany*

WZB Fellow — *Aug 2023 – Present*

Research Fellow — *Nov 2020 – Aug 2023*

Institute for Social and Economic Research and Policy, Columbia University — *New York, NY, US*

Research Staff Assistant — *Oct 2021 – Aug 2023*

International Center for the Study of Institutions and Development, HSE University — *Moscow, Russia*

Research Fellow — *Jul 2020 – Dec 2022*

Education

Department of Political Science, Columbia University — *New York, NY, US*

Doctor of Philosophy — *May 2022*

Dissertation: *The Media under Autocracy: Essays on Domestic Politics and Government Support in Russia*.
Committee: Timothy Frye, Macartan Humphreys, Donald Green, Katerina Tertytchnaya, Scott Gehlbach.

Master of Philosophy — *Oct 2017*

Master of Arts — *Oct 2016*

Laboratory for Applied Analysis of Institutions and Social Capital (CInSt), HSE University — *Moscow, Russia*

Candidate of Sciences (PhD Equivalent) — *Nov 2014*

Dissertation: *Effects of Elite Turnover on Property Rights Protection: Theoretical and Empirical Analysis*.
Advisor: Leonid Polishchuk.

Department of Economics, HSE University — *Moscow, Russia*

Master of Economics — *Jul 2011*

Bachelor of Economics — *Jul 2009*

Publications

Peer-Reviewed Articles

Making, Updating, and Querying Causal Models with `CausalQueries` — *JSS*

T. Tietz, L. Medina, **G. Syunyaev**, M. Humphreys — *117(1), 2026*

Decentralization and Ideology — *PSRM*

A. Wilke, **G. Syunyaev**, M. Ting — *14(1): 231–239, 2026*

COVID-19 Vaccine Acceptance and Hesitancy in Low- and Middle-Income Countries — *Nature Medicine*

J.S. Solís Arce, S.S. Warren, N.F. Meriggi, A. Scacco, N. McMurry, M. Voors, **G. Syunyaev**, A.A. Malik, S. Aboutajdine, and others *(co-first author)* — *27(8): 1385–1394, 2021*

Ruling Elites' Rotation and Asset Ownership: Implications for Property Rights — *Public Choice*

L. Polishchuk, **G. Syunyaev** — *162(1): 159–182, 2015*

How (not) to Measure Russian Regional Institutions — *RuJE*

A. Baranov, E. Malkov, L. Polishchuk, M. Rochlitz, **G. Syunyaev** — *1(2): 154–181, 2015*

Investment Climate and Government Turnover in Russian Regions — *Voprosy Ekonomiki* (in Russian)

G. Syunyaev, L. Polishchuk — *(2): 88–117, 2014*

Book Chapters

Property Rights without Democracy: The Role of Elites' Rotation and Asset Ownership. In C. Dahlström and L. Wängnerud (eds.), *Elites, Institutions and the Quality of Government*
L. Polishchuk, **G. Syunyaev**
Palgrave Macmillan
pp. 167–186, 2015

Non-Academic Writing

Can Russians Learn to Recognize Propaganda? Understanding of Media Bias Amid the Ukraine War
A. Shirikov, **G. Syunyaev**
PONARS Eurasia Policy Memo
No. 918, 2024

COVID-19 Vaccine Acceptance in Low- and Middle-Income Countries and Recommendations to Increase Uptake
J.S. Solís Arce, S.S. Warren, N.F. Meriggi, A. Scacco, N. McMurry, M. Voors, **G. Syunyaev**, and others
IPA Policy Brief
2021

Working Papers

The Debate Is the Message: Contested Support and Refugee Incorporation
H. Hilbig, F. Sichart, **G. Syunyaev**
Under review
2026

Countering Authoritarian Censorship via Grassroots Communication Campaigns: Evidence from an Experimental Mega-Study in Wartime Russia
J. Minson, A. Erlich, J. Gans-Morse, C. Higgins, …, **G. Syunyaev**, … (26 authors)
Under review
2026

Still Watching, Less Persuaded: Attention to News Reduces Authoritarian Propaganda Effectiveness
A. Shirikov, **G. Syunyaev**
Working paper
2025

Persuasion without Deception: Why Propaganda Works Even When Its Bias Is Known
G. Syunyaev
Working paper
2026

Limits of Independent Media in Autocracies: Evidence from Local News in Russia
G. Syunyaev
Working paper
2025

Internet Access and Political Engagement: Evidence from South Africa
G. Syunyaev, A. Jang, A. Wilke, B. Laughlin, K. Malindi
Working paper
2026

Work in Progress

Biases in the Measurement of Hidden Populations
G. Syunyaev, M. Humphreys
Manuscript in preparation

Deciding Whom to Trust: Measuring and Improving How Citizens Evaluate News Sources Under Uncertainty
G. Syunyaev, A. Shirikov
Design

The Autocrat's Two Bodies: Public Image as a Signal of Regime Stability
G. Syunyaev, M. Turchenko
Design

Internet Blocking and Shutdowns in Russia
G. Syunyaev
Design

Software

`hiddenmeta`: diagnosis and meta-analysis of hard-to-reach population studies
Author and maintainer (with M. Humphreys and T. Tietz)
R package

`CausalQueries`: make, update, and query binary causal models
Contributor
R package, CRAN

`DeclareDesign`: declare and diagnose research designs
Early contributor
R package, CRAN

Grants & Fellowships

2025	**Research Subaward, *Meta-Analysis of Hard-to-Reach Population Studies***, University of Georgia	*Athens, GA*
2023	**Research Credits, *Foreign Policy Debates Shape Refugees' Psychological Integration* (with H. Hilbig and F. Sichart)**, Meta	
2020	**Summer Dissertation Writing Grant**, ASEEES	
2020	**Ph.D. Research Grant, *Learning about Bias* (with A. Shirikov)**, Harriman Institute, Columbia University, and Carnegie Corporation of New York	*New York, NY*
2019	**Russian Study Research Grant**, Harriman Institute, Columbia University	*New York, NY*
2018–2019	**Dissertation Fellowship**, Graduate School of Arts and Sciences, Columbia University	*New York, NY*
2018	**Russian Study Research Grant**, Harriman Institute, Columbia University	*New York, NY*
2017–2018	**Research Transparency and Reproducibility Fellowship**, J-PAL, MIT	*Cambridge, MA*
2017	**Governance Initiative Travel Grant (with A. Wilke and T. Leavitt)**, J-PAL, MIT	*Cambridge, MA*
2017	**Dissertation Development Grant**, Department of Political Science, Columbia University	*New York, NY*
2016, 2017	**Travel Grant**, Department of Political Science, Columbia University	*New York, NY*
2014	**Dean's Fellowship**, Graduate School of Arts and Sciences, Columbia University	*New York, NY*
2013	**Research Grant of the Department of Economics**, HSE University	*Moscow, Russia*
2011	**Research Grant of the Department of Economics (with L. Polishchuk)**, HSE University	*Moscow, Russia*
2010–2014	**Travel Grants for Participation in Five Academic Conferences**, HSE University	*Moscow, Russia*

Teaching

Statistics for Political Research II (PSCI 8357) — *Vanderbilt University*
Graduate seminar — *Spring 2025, 2026*

Data Collection Methods (PSCI 8362) — *Vanderbilt University*
Graduate seminar — *Spring 2024*

Post-Soviet Politics of Russia and Ukraine (PSCI 2218) — *Vanderbilt University*
Undergraduate lecture course — *Spring 2024, 2025, 2026*

Conducting Political Research (PSCI 2270 / PSCI 3156) — *Vanderbilt University*
Undergraduate research seminar — *Fall 2023, 2024*